THE LEADING QUESTION AUTOPSY

Find the questions in your script that will get you lied to.

Not maliciously. Politely. Most people will tell a founder what the founder obviously wants to hear. This sheet finds the questions that invite it, and makes you rewrite them before you spend a real conversation on them.

15 MINUTES | 6 PAGES | PRINT IT · WRITE ON IT | BRING A PEN AND YOUR SCRIPT

YOU WROTE — ILLUSTRATIVE

~~"Would you use an app that automatically organises all your receipts?"~~

LEADING | HYPOTHETICAL | SOLUTION-BIASED

ASK INSTEAD

"Tell me about the last time you had to find a receipt."

three problems in one sentence ↑

01 · LEARN
The Three Tells: the three ways a question gives the answer away. (p.2)

02 · DRILL
Spot them in 12 illustrative questions, then check the key. (p.3–4)

03 · AUDIT
Run your own script through the test, score it, rewrite the worst. (p.5–6)

FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

A question can give its answer away in three ways. We call them the Three Tells.

Start from first principles. An interview is a measurement. You want to measure what a person **has actually done**, because that is the closest thing to what they will do. Each Tell swaps that measurement for something cheaper: your opinion, their guess, or their politeness.

TELL 1 · LEADING

The answer you want is inside the question.

It tells them which reply is correct. Most people are kind to a nervous founder, so they pick it.

> *"Don't you hate chasing late invoices?"*

TEST → Could a polite stranger see which answer I'm hoping for?

TELL 2 · HYPOTHETICAL

It asks for a forecast, not a memory.

"Would you", "how much would you pay", "do you think people…". Asking someone to predict their own behaviour gets you an optimistic guess.

> *"If this existed, how often would you use it?"*

TEST → Is it about the future, or about other people?

TELL 3 · SOLUTION-BIASED

Your idea has walked into the room.

Once they know what you're building, they review your idea instead of describing their life, and they are polite about it.

> *"Our tool uses AI to auto-chase clients. Useful?"*

TEST → Does it mention my product, feature or idea?

NO TELLS · CLEAN

ask for a memory, get a story

"Tell me about the last time that happened." A clean question asks about a specific past event. It gets you a date, a workaround, a cost and a person: things that happened, not things they imagine. Then keep going: *What did you do next? What did that cost you? What have you tried?*

WHAT THE RESEARCH ACTUALLY SAYS

AND HOW SURE TO BE ABOUT IT

People say they'd pay more than they actually do. A meta-analysis comparing stated and real-money valuations found stated amounts were higher, with a median ratio of about 1.35×; other reviews report larger gaps.

Murphy, Allen, Stevens & Weatherhead (2005), *Environmental & Resource Economics* 30(3).

DIRECTION: SOLID

SIZE: VARIES A LOT

Changing what people intend changes what they do much less. Across 47 experiments, shifting intentions produced a noticeably smaller shift in behaviour, and the gap grew with time.

Webb & Sheeran (2006), *Psychological Bulletin* 132(2).

REPLICATED

HEALTH & SOCIAL BEHAVIOUR, NOT PURCHASES

One word can move the answer. People who were asked how fast cars "smashed" into each other gave higher speed estimates than people asked how fast they "contacted".

Loftus & Palmer (1974), *Journal of Verbal Learning and Verbal Behavior* 13(5).

CLASSIC LAB STUDY

AN ANALOGY FOR INTERVIEWS

Builds on Rob Fitzpatrick's *The Mom Test* and Y Combinator's "How to Talk to Users". This sheet is the drill, not the book.

Spot the Tells.

Twelve questions a founder of an invoicing tool for freelancers might ask. Tick every Tell you see. A question can have more than one. Tick **Clean** only if it has none.

ALL EXAMPLES ILLUSTRATIVE

	QUESTION	LEADING	HYPO-THETICAL	SOLUTION	CLEAN
01	"Would you use an app that automatically organises your receipts?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
02	"Tell me about the last time you had to find a receipt."	☐	☐	☐	☐
03	"Don't you hate chasing late invoices?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
04	"How much would you pay for something that fixed this?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
05	"What did you do about it the last time a client paid late?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
06	"Our tool uses AI to chase clients for you. Does that sound useful?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
07	"If this existed, how often do you think you'd use it?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
08	"What's the hardest part of getting paid for your work?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
09	"Wouldn't it be easier if your invoices just sent themselves?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
10	"Have you tried anything to fix this? What happened?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
11	"Do you think other freelancers struggle with this too?"	☐	☐	☐	☐
12	"On a scale of 1 to 10, how painful is invoicing for you?"	☐	☐	☐	☐

Before you turn the page: which one of these have you asked, word for word or close to it? No. _____

The key, and why.

If you disagree with a call, good: argue it out loud. The reasoning matters more than the tick.

	TELLS	WHY, AND A CLEANER VERSION
01	L H S	Pitches the app, asks for a forecast, and "would you use" has one polite answer. → *"Tell me about the last time you had to find a receipt."*
02	CLEAN	A specific past event. Follow with: *"What did you do? How long did it take?"*
03	L	"Don't you hate..." tells them what to feel. → *"Walk me through what happens when a client pays late."*
04	H S	Stated prices run higher than real ones (see p.2). → *"What have you paid for anything that helps with this? What do you pay now?"*
05	CLEAN	Past, specific, no idea mentioned. Dig into the workaround they describe.
06	L S	A pitch with a question mark at the end. Hold the solution back until you've heard the problem in their words.
07	H S	"If this existed" is both a hypothetical and your product. → *"How often did this come up last month?"*
08	CLEAN	Open and about their world. It's one of YC's suggested openers. Follow up with *"When did that last happen?"* to get from opinion to a story.
09	L S	"Wouldn't it be..." is the leading form, and auto-sending invoices is your feature in disguise.
10	CLEAN	Gold. What they have already tried, paid for or hacked together is the strongest signal that the problem is real.
11	H	Asks them to speculate about other people. → *"Who else have you talked to about this? What did they do?"*
12	L	Assumes it is painful and asks for an opinion score. → *"How long did invoicing take you last month?"*

YOUR DRILL SCORE

_____ / **12** rows fully right

Missed any? Circle them. A Tell you didn't spot on paper is one you're likely to ask out loud. Those are your blind spots.

Now do it to yourself.

Write the questions you actually plan to ask in your next interview, word for word. For each one, answer the four checks honestly. Any **yes** is a Tell.

A · SOLUTION
Does it mention my idea, product or feature?

B · FUTURE
Is it about the future, a "would", or other people?

C · LEADING
Is the answer I want hidden inside it?

D · COMPLIMENT
Could they answer "yeah, sounds great" and move on?

	MY QUESTION, EXACTLY AS I'D SAY IT	A YES?	B YES?	C YES?	D YES?	CLEAN (ALL NO)
1		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
2		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
3		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
4		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
5		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
6		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
7		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐
8		☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

CLEAN QUESTIONS

____ / 8

MOST COMMON TELL

A B C D (circle)

FIX FIRST

Any **B**. A forecast is the weakest data an interview can collect.

Be harsh. Then ask yourself honestly: would a stranger reading these questions have marked them the same way?

Before → after.

Take the three questions with the most Tells. Rewrite each one to ask about something that has already happened. Tip: start with "Tell me about the last time…" or "What did you do when…"

BEFORE	AFTER
BEFORE	AFTER
BEFORE	AFTER

THE PART PAPER CAN'T DO

You ask your clean opener. They smile and say: **"Oh yeah, I'd totally use something like that."** What do you say next, live, without pitching?

DID YOU MARK YOURSELF FAIRLY?

PAPER DOESN'T ANSWER BACK

Rehearse here. Learn out there.

Unassumed puts your questions in front of a synthetic customer who objects, digresses and refuses to be led. Then it scores **your questions**, not your idea. It's practice, not proof: a cheap place to find your leading questions before you spend a real conversation on them. Only a real customer is evidence.

Join the first cohort → unassumed.com

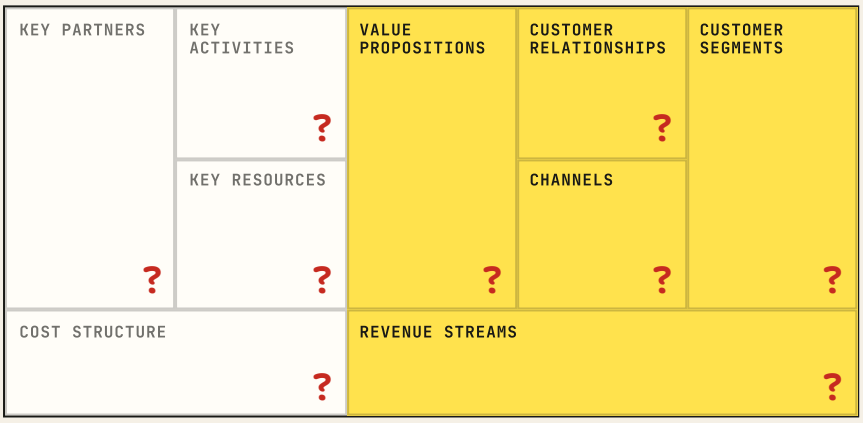
PRIVATE BETA · ONE EMAIL WHEN YOUR SEAT OPENS · NO DRIP SEQUENCE

THE CANVAS INTERROGATION

Your canvas is a list of guesses.

A filled-in business model canvas looks like a plan, but every box is a belief nobody has tested yet. This sheet turns the nine boxes into sentences a stranger could prove wrong, finds the three that would sink you, and plans this week's cheapest test of each.

30 MINUTES | 6 PAGES | WORKS WITH ANY CANVAS | INCLUDES 5 HONEST AI PROMPTS



nine boxes, nine guesses. The yellow ones decide whether anyone wants it at all. Interrogate those first.

Layout after the Business Model Canvas by Strategyzer AG (CC BY-SA). The official blank canvas is free at strategyzer.com.

01 · INTERROGATE
Rewrite each box as a guess someone could disprove. (p.2)

02 · RANK
Plot the guesses by importance and evidence. Find your kill list. (p.3)

03 · TEST
Map one cheap test for each of your top three. (p.4)

04 · USE AI HONESTLY
Five prompts that find guesses instead of flattering them. (p.5)

FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

Ask each box one hard question.

Write your guess as a sentence a stranger could prove wrong: `We believe [who] [does / has / will pay for what], because [what we've actually seen].` If the "because" is empty, that tells you something too.

BOX	THE QUESTION TO ASK IT	OUR GUESS, AS A SENTENCE SOMEONE COULD DISPROVE
WILL ANYONE WANT IT? · START HERE		
Customer segments WHO	Can I name three real people who had this problem in the last month?	
Value proposition WHY THEM	What do they do about it today, and what does that cost them?	
Channels HOW THEY FIND US	Where did the last person with this problem go looking for help?	
Customer relationships HOW WE KEEP THEM	Is this a one-off problem or a recurring one? How do I know?	
Revenue streams WHO PAYS, HOW	What have they already paid to solve it, and who signed off?	
CAN WE DELIVER IT? · THEN THESE		
Key activities WHAT WE MUST DO WELL	What's the one thing that, done badly, makes the rest pointless?	
Key resources WHAT WE NEED	What do we need that we don't yet have, and how sure are we we can get it?	
Key partners WHO WE DEPEND ON	Who would have to say yes, and have we asked them?	
CAN IT PAY? · THEN THIS		
Cost structure WHAT IT COSTS	What does it cost us to win and serve one customer? Is that a guess?	

Why this order? If nobody wants it, nothing else on the canvas matters, so test desirability ("will anyone want it?") before feasibility and viability. Number each guess 1–9 for the next page.

ORDER IS A RULE OF THUMB

Plot your nine guesses.

Write each guess's number on the map. **Up** = how badly the business breaks if it's wrong. **Right** = how much real evidence you have. Your kill list is the top-left: important guesses with no evidence behind them.

BREAKS THE BUSINESS ↑

KILL LIST · TEST THESE FIRST Important, and you're running on belief. Your top three go straight to page 4.	**KEEP WATCHING** Important, with some evidence. Re-check as you learn more.
PARK IT Unproven, but it won't sink you. Leave it alone for now.	**FINE FOR NOW** Low stakes and supported. Stop thinking about it.

LOW IMPORTANCE ↓

NO EVIDENCE → STRONG EVIDENCE

Prioritising by importance and evidence follows the assumptions-mapping approach in Bland & Osterwalder's *Testing Business Ideas*.

WHAT COUNTS AS EVIDENCE? SCORE HONESTLY BEFORE YOU PLOT

NONE	NONE	WEAK	GOOD	STRONG
A compliment "Love it!" costs them nothing.	**A forecast** "I'd use that", "people would pay".	**A past story** A specific time it happened to them.	**A workaround** Time or money they already spend on it.	**A commitment** Time, an intro, a deposit, now.

Your own conviction isn't on the ladder. Neither is your mum's.

One cheap test per guess.

FILL IN BEFORE YOU START

Decide what "wrong" looks like **before** you start. Writing the failure condition in advance is the whole trick, because afterwards you'll want to move the line.

KILL-LIST GUESS #1 · WE BELIEVE…

CHEAPEST TEST (≤ 7 DAYS, NO PRODUCT)	WHAT WE'LL COUNT
WE'RE WRONG IF…	RESULT · DATE

KILL-LIST GUESS #2 · WE BELIEVE…

CHEAPEST TEST (≤ 7 DAYS, NO PRODUCT)	WHAT WE'LL COUNT
WE'RE WRONG IF…	RESULT · DATE

KILL-LIST GUESS #3 · WE BELIEVE…

CHEAPEST TEST (≤ 7 DAYS, NO PRODUCT)	WHAT WE'LL COUNT
WE'RE WRONG IF…	RESULT · DATE

A STARTER MENU OF CHEAP TESTS

ILLUSTRATIVE · ROUGHLY CHEAPEST FIRST

Dig for workarounds
Search forums and reviews for people already hacking a fix or paying for one.

Five conversations
Past-behaviour interviews with people from your segment. See field sheets 01 & 03.

Do it by hand
Deliver the outcome manually for one or two people before you build anything.

A one-page offer
Describe it plainly with a clear ask, and count who takes the next step.

Ask for commitment
A deposit, letter of intent or intro. The strongest signal, and the scariest ask.

Does this way of working actually help? In a randomised trial, early-stage founders trained to frame ideas as hypotheses and test them dropped weak ideas sooner and earned more revenue than a control group. A larger replication also found benefits. Camuffo, Cordova, Gambardella & Spina, *Management Science* (2020); replication in *Strategic Management Journal* (2024).

Five prompts that find guesses instead of flattering them.

ILLUSTRATIVE · ADAPT FREELY

Chatbots are useful for spotting what you're assuming, and bad at telling you whether you're right. Ask the first kind of question, never the second. Paste your canvas from page 2 where it says […].

1	SURFACE THE GUESSES	Here is my business model canvas: […]. List every assumption hidden in it as a sentence that a stranger could prove false. Do not tell me whether the idea is good.
2	MAKE THEM FALSIFIABLE	For each assumption, describe what I would actually observe in the world if it were false. Be concrete: who does what, how often.
3	ARGUE THE OTHER SIDE	Act as a sceptical investor who has seen 500 ideas like this fail. Which three assumptions, if wrong, would end this business? Give the strongest case against each.
4	DESIGN THE CHEAPEST TEST	Design the cheapest test of this assumption that I can run in seven days without building a product: […]. State in advance the result that would mean I'm wrong.
5	CHECK YOUR QUESTIONS	Here are the questions I plan to ask in customer interviews: […]. Flag any that are leading, hypothetical, or mention my solution, and rewrite them to ask about specific past behaviour.

WHAT A CHATBOT CAN'T TELL YOU

Whether anyone will pay. Researchers who compared language-model answers with a real national survey found them similar on average, but analyses of the synthetic answers often reached different conclusions from the human data.

Bisbee et al. (2024), "Synthetic Replacements for Human Survey Data? The Perils of Large Language Models", *Political Analysis* 32.

Use AI to find guesses.
Use people to test them.
Never ask a chatbot if your idea is good.

Your assumption ledger.

Update this after every test and every conversation. A guess only changes status when a real person did or said something, and you write down who and when.

#	ASSUMPTION	STATUS	EVIDENCE: WHAT SOMEONE DID OR SAID	WHO · WHEN
1		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
2		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
3		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
4		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		
5		○ UNTESTED ○ SUPPORTED ○ CONTRADICTED		

A contradicted assumption isn't a failure. It's the cheapest thing you'll learn all year.

PAPER DOESN'T ANSWER BACK

From scribble to evidence, without the theatre.

Unassumed does this loop with you. A note, voice memo or napkin photo becomes a first-pass canvas you can argue with. Every box becomes an assumption with a status. You rehearse the conversations that could break it against a synthetic customer who won't be led, then log what real people actually said. No idea score. No "validated" stamp. Just what has happened to each belief, who said it, and when.

Join the first cohort → unassumed.com

YOUR FIRST FIVE CONVERSATIONS

The scary part isn't the questions. It's the first message.

Plenty of founders know they should talk to customers and still put it off for weeks, because it means asking strangers for time and hearing "no". This sheet makes the first five conversations small and specific: who to ask, what to send, how to spend the 30 minutes, and what to write down afterwards.

ONE WEEK | 6 PAGES | NO NETWORK NEEDED | NO PITCH DECK ALLOWED

NAME THE FEAR BEFORE IT NAMES YOU

WHAT I'M WORRIED WILL HAPPEN

THE WORST REALISTIC OUTCOME

WHAT I LOSE IF I DON'T ASK

a "no" costs you a minute. building the wrong thing costs months.

01 · FIND
Ten names, warmest first, no network required. (p.2)

02 · ASK
Three messages that ask for a story, not a favour. (p.3)

03 · RUN
A 30-minute run sheet, plus what to say when it goes sideways. (p.4)

04 · TRACK
Five calls, one page, and a courage log. (p.5)

FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

Start warm. Cold is the last resort.

From first principles: people say yes when they already care about the problem, or when someone they trust asks them to. Founders who share their outreach stories publicly tend to report the same thing: cold messages mostly go unanswered, while warm intros and people already complaining get replies. So work left to right.

WARMEST	WARM	MILD	COOL	COLD
Already complaining	**One intro away**	**Where they gather**	**Your own past**	**Strangers**
People posting about this problem in forums, reviews, groups. Reply helpfully first. Check each community's rules on self-promotion.	Ask friends, ex-colleagues, classmates: "Who do you know who has dealt with ___ recently?"	Meetups, associations, Slack and Discord groups, courses where your segment already spends time.	People from old jobs, clients, suppliers who fit the segment, even loosely.	Short, specific, no pitch. Expect silence; send more than you need.

MY TEN: PEOPLE WHO HAD THIS PROBLEM RECENTLY

	NAME OR HANDLE	WHERE I FOUND THEM	WARMTH	MESSAGE SENT?
01			W · M · C	
02			W · M · C	
03			W · M · C	
04			W · M · C	
05			W · M · C	
06			W · M · C	
07			W · M · C	
08			W · M · C	
09			W · M · C	
10			W · M · C	

Why five, and why ten names? Five conversations won't prove anything. They tell you whether you're talking to the right people and asking the right questions. Research on interview saturation suggests recurring themes start to repeat after roughly a dozen or so interviews in a fairly similar group, and later when the group is mixed. Ten names gets you five calls if half say yes. Guest, Bunce & Johnson (2006), *Field Methods* 18(1); Hagaman & Wutich (2016), *Field Methods*.

Ask for their story, not your validation.

People like being asked about their own experience. They don't enjoy being asked to judge your idea. Fill in the blanks, keep it short, and send it today.

A · THE WARM-INTRO ASK

TO A FRIEND

Hi _____, quick favour. I'm trying to understand how _____ deal with _____. Do you know anyone who's had to deal with that in the last few months? I'd love 20 minutes to hear how they handle it. I'm not selling anything.

Why it works: you're asking for an introduction, not a sale, and "in the last few months" filters for people with fresh, specific memories.

B · THE REPLY TO SOMEONE WHO COMPLAINED

PUBLIC POST → DM

Hi _____, I saw your post about _____. That sounds painful. I'm researching how people handle this and I'm not selling anything. Would you be up for a 20-minute chat about what happened and what you tried? Happy to share what I learn from others.

Why it works: they've already told the world it's a problem. Lead with their words, and offer something back (a summary of what you learn).

C · THE COLD EMAIL

LAST RESORT

Subject: Quick question about _____

Hi _____, I'm researching how _____ handle _____, and your work at _____ suggests you've seen it up close. Could I ask you about the last time it came up? 20 minutes, your choice of time, and no pitch. If it's not a fit, a one-line "no" is genuinely fine.

Why it works: it's specific about why you chose them, it gives them permission to say no, and it promises no pitch. Then keep that promise.

NEVER IN A FIRST MESSAGE

"Validate"
It tells them you want a yes.

A deck or a link
It turns a chat into a review.

"Would you use…"
Save it. Better still, never ask it.

An hour
Ask for 20 minutes and finish on time.

Thirty minutes, in four parts.

Print this and keep it beside you on the call. Write in the margins. Change it after every conversation.

0–3′ SET-UP	**Lower the stakes.** *“I’m not selling anything. I’m trying to understand how people deal with ___. There are no wrong answers, and specific stories help me most.”*
3–18′ THE LAST TIME	**One real event, in detail.** • *“Tell me about the last time ___ happened.”* • *“What happened just before that? And after?”* • *“What did you try? What did it cost you, in time or money?”* • *“Who else was involved?”*
18–25′ THEIR WORLD	**Zoom out, still about them.** • *“What’s the hardest part about ___?”* • *“Have you looked for a better way? What happened?”* • *“How does this rank against everything else on your plate?”*
25–30′ CLOSE	**Ask for one next step.** • *“Who else should I talk to about this?”* • *“Can I come back to you once I’ve spoken to a few more people?”*

Openers adapted from Y Combinator’s “How to Talk to Users” and Rob Fitzpatrick’s *The Mom Test*.

WHEN IT GOES SIDEWAYS

THEY SAY “Oh, I’d totally use something like that.”	YOU SAY “Thanks! What are you using today? What did it cost you last time?”
THEY START DESIGNING YOUR PRODUCT “You should add a feature that…”	YOU SAY “Interesting. Has that come up for you? When was the last time?”
YOU CATCH YOURSELF PITCHING You’ve been talking for two minutes straight.	YOU DO Stop mid-sentence. *“Sorry, I’m talking too much. Tell me about the last time…”*
THEY GO VAGUE “Usually I just sort of deal with it.”	YOU SAY “Could you walk me through the most recent time, step by step?”

Five calls, one page.

After each call, fill in one row before you do anything else. For the full debrief, use field sheet 04, “The Compliment Trap”.

	WHO (ROLE)	DATE	THE BEST FACT I HEARD (SOMETHING THAT HAPPENED)	NEXT STEP THEY AGREED TO
1				○ NONE
2				○ NONE
3				○ NONE
4				○ NONE
5				○ NONE

COURAGE LOG: WHAT I FEARED VS. WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED

	BEFORE THE CALL I WAS WORRIED THAT…	WHAT ACTUALLY HAPPENED
1		
2		
3		
4		
5		

AFTER FIVE CALLS, ASK YOURSELF

Did the same problem come up unprompted more than once? Was I talking to the right kind of person? Which of my questions got stories, and which got opinions?

then book the next five.

INTERVIEW #1 IS THE ONE YOU CAN'T REDO

Rehearse it first.

You get one first conversation with each person. Unassumed gives you as many practice runs as you need before it: a synthetic customer who objects, digresses, goes vague and won't be led, and then a review of **your questions**, not your idea.

SCRIBBLE

A note or napkin photo becomes a first-pass canvas.

REHEARSE

Practise the pushback before a real person sees you sweat.

EVIDENCE

Log what real people said, and watch which beliefs survive.

AI IS REHEARSAL. CUSTOMERS ARE EVIDENCE.

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PRIVATE BETA · ONE EMAIL WHEN YOUR SEAT OPENS · NO DRIP SEQUENCE

THE COMPLIMENT TRAP · A 10-MINUTE POST-CALL DEBRIEF

Was that interview good, or did they just like you?

Do this within ten minutes of hanging up, before you message your co-founder "they loved it". That is exactly when a compliment quietly turns into "they'd pay", and the notes never get written.

10 MINUTES | ONE SHEET PER CALL | PRINT FIVE COPIES

EVERYTHING THEY SAID GOES IN ONE OF FOUR BINS

COMPLIMENT

Praise for you or your idea.

> *"That's a really cool idea."*

WORTH: NOTHING. IT COST THEM NOTHING TO SAY.

FLUFF

Generic claims, hypotheticals, "I would", "I usually", "people like me".

> *"I'd definitely use something like that."*

WORTH: NOTHING. IT'S A FORECAST.

FACT

Something that already happened: a specific time, workaround, cost or person.

> *"Last March I lost two days rebuilding a client's invoice history."*

WORTH: REAL. THIS IS DATA.

COMMITMENT

They gave up something now: time, reputation or money.

> *"Let me introduce you to our finance lead."*

WORTH: MOST. THIS IS EVIDENCE.

The idea that a compliment is worth nothing, and a commitment of time, reputation or money is worth a lot, comes from Rob Fitzpatrick's *The Mom Test*. This sheet just makes you sort the pile while it's still warm.

"they loved it" is not a finding.

FREE TO PRINT AND SHARE. KEEP THIS FOOTER.

WHO (ROLE, NOT NAME) _____ DATE _____ THE ASSUMPTION I WAS TESTING _____

Write down the eight things they said that you remember most, as close to word-for-word as you can. Then tick one bin for each. Don't tidy them up or round them up to what you wanted to hear.

	WHAT THEY ACTUALLY SAID	COMPLI-MENT	FLUFF	FACT	COMMIT-MENT
1		☐	☐	☐	☐
2		☐	☐	☐	☐
3		☐	☐	☐	☐
4		☐	☐	☐	☐
5		☐	☐	☐	☐
6		☐	☐	☐	☐
7		☐	☐	☐	☐
8		☐	☐	☐	☐
	TOTAL TICKS →	---	---	---	---

WHICH QUESTION INVITED THE COMPLIMENTS?

THE SINGLE BEST FACT I HEARD

DID THE ASSUMPTION MOVE?

Only facts and commitments are allowed to move it. Compliments and fluff can't.

↑ STRONGER ↓ WEAKER — NO CHANGE

THE NEXT STEP THEY AGREED TO (IF NONE, WRITE "NONE")

What your ticks are telling you.

These aren't scores. They point at what to change before the next call.

MOSTLY COMPLIMENTS	**You probably pitched.** Once your idea is in the room, people react to it politely. Next time, hold the solution back until the last five minutes, or leave it out entirely.
MOSTLY FLUFF	**You asked about the future.** "Would you…" and "how often do you…" get you forecasts. Swap them for "tell me about the last time…". Field sheet 01 drills exactly this.
FACTS, NO COMMITMENT	**A good conversation that didn't go anywhere.** You learned something real. Next time, ask for a next step before you hang up (see the ladder below). A "no" is information too.
AT LEAST ONE COMMITMENT	**That's evidence.** Write it in your assumption list with the date and who it was. One commitment from a stranger outweighs a pile of compliments from friends.

THE COMMITMENT LADDER: ASK FOR ONE RUNG BEFORE YOU HANG UP

TIME

- A follow-up call with a clear purpose
- Looking at a rough sketch with you
- Trying a manual version for a week

REPUTATION

- An introduction to a colleague with the same problem
- An intro to whoever signs off the spending

MONEY

- A pre-order or deposit
- A letter of intent
- Paying for the manual version

The time, reputation and money categories follow *The Mom Test*. Reputation-type asks usually fit B2B better than consumer products.

ACROSS YOUR CALLS: STICK THE TOTALS HERE

CALL	WHO · compliments not shrinking? check your questions before you blame the market	COMPL.	FLUFF	FACTS	COMMIT.	MOVED?
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						

PAPER DOESN'T ANSWER BACK

Find the compliment-bait before the call.

This sheet tells you *after* the call that a question invited a compliment. Unassumed lets you find out *before*: rehearse against a synthetic customer who objects, digresses and won't be led, then see which of your questions did the leading. It's practice, not proof. Only a real customer is evidence.

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